

STAGE THREE • JOB APPLICATION & INTERVIEW SKILLS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Three • Job Application & Interview Skills

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Three carries more emotional weight than most stages — rejection, interview anxiety, negotiation guilt, and sometimes a genuine real offer decision happening in real time. Part 4 in particular deserves close attention here.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck or anxious.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Three. Everything from Stages One and Two — who you are, how you present yourself — now gets put to work in an actual job search. Today is about building the operational backbone: tracking, strategy, tailored materials, and your core interview stories.”

“A quick honest note before we start: this stage deals directly with rejection, and most of us have a lot of it in our history. That's completely normal, and today is about building a genuinely better system, not about anything being wrong with you if past attempts didn't land.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about getting your materials and stories ready. Today is about performing under real interview conditions — technical questions, case problems, a full mock interview, and even negotiating an offer.”

“This is our most intensive session. Several exercises today involve being watched or timed, which is uncomfortable on purpose — that discomfort is closer to a real interview than anything untimed and solo could be.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session is about everything around the interview itself: your mindset beforehand, your follow-up after, staying organized across multiple processes, and making a clear-headed decision when a real offer arrives.”

“This is often the least glamorous part of a job search, but it's frequently where people who are otherwise strong candidates lose ground — a missed deadline, a forgotten thank-you, an offer decision made on adrenaline instead of clarity.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST C1 → C2

“Now that you have a system for tracking applications, let's make sure what you're actually tracking reflects a genuine strategy, not just volume for its own sake.”

FIRST C5 → C6

“You've just learned to decode what a job listing is really asking for. Now let's build the actual interview answers that respond to what you found.”

Session 1 → Session 2

“Your materials and stories are ready. Now we test them under real conditions — time pressure, a live audience, genuine unpredictability.”

FIRST C9 → C10

“You've practiced structured thinking out loud for a case problem. A mock interview puts that, and everything else so far, into one continuous, realistic conversation.”

FIRST C10 → C11

“You just practiced performing under interview pressure. Negotiation is a different kind of pressure — the pressure of a real number on the table and a fear of seeming ungrateful.”

Session 2 → Session 3

“You can now perform well in the interview room. This final session is about everything that happens before you walk in and after you walk out — which matters just as much.”

FIRST C17 → C18

“Now that your deadlines are under control, let's talk about a way to get ahead of some of them entirely — a warm introduction instead of a cold application.”

FIRST C19 → C20

“You've learned to research a company before an interview. The final piece is knowing how to evaluate one clearly once a real offer is actually on the table.”

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone shares a discouraging rejection history during discussion

“That's a genuinely hard pattern to sit with. What's one thing, even small, that's different about your approach today compared to those earlier applications?” (Redirect toward the concrete system being built, not just sympathy.)

A participant freezes or blanks during a mock interview or STAR practice

“Take a breath — that happens to everyone, including in real interviews. Let's back up: what's the actual result you're proud of in this story? Start there and work backward.”

Negotiation role-play feels awkward or participants default to accepting immediately

“Notice what just happened — how quickly did ‘yes’ come out? That instinct is completely normal, and it's exactly what we're building a counter to today.”

A participant argues a specific piece of common interview advice is wrong or doesn't apply to them

“Tell me more about that — what's happened in your experience that makes this advice not fit? Sometimes that reveals something real about your specific field or situation worth adjusting for.”

Someone is visibly anxious about an upcoming real interview during this stage

“What specifically about it feels most uncertain right now? Let's see if there's something concrete from today's session that actually addresses that piece directly.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, anxious, or need extra care — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST C3

Resume Version A/B Test

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants sometimes want to change multiple resume elements at once between versions, which defeats the purpose of a genuine test. Push firmly for one variable at a time, even though it feels slower — otherwise the “data” from the test is meaningless.

FIRST C10

Mock Interview

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the single most anxiety-provoking exercise in the stage for many participants. Let people choose their own partner or a facilitator-assigned one rather than a public volunteer call if the room feels tense, and always build in the honest feedback conversation afterward — skipping it wastes most of the exercise's real value.

FIRST C11

Job Offer Negotiation Prep

FACILITATOR NOTE

Many participants, especially those newer to the workforce or from backgrounds where negotiating wasn't modeled, feel genuine guilt or fear about negotiating at all. Normalize it directly: most first offers have real room, and asking respectfully doesn't damage genuine enthusiasm for a role.

FIRST C20

Offer Comparison Matrix

FACILITATOR NOTE

If a participant has a real offer in hand during this stage, this exercise can carry genuine real-world weight and stress. Be ready to have a private, individual conversation rather than working through their specific real decision in front of the full group.